

Fasting (صوم)

The Fast

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا كُتِبَ عَلَيْكُمُ الصِّيَامُ كَمَا كُتِبَ عَلَى الَّذِينَ مِن قَبْلِكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَّقُونَ
أَيَّامًا مَّعْدُودَاتٍ ۚ فَمَن كَانَ مِنكُم مَّرِيضًا أَوْ عَلَى سَفَرٍ فَعِدَّةٌ مِّنْ أَيَّامٍ أُخَرَ ۚ وَعَلَى الَّذِينَ
يُطِيقُونَهُ ۖ فِدْيَةٌ طَعَامُ مِسْكِينٍ ۚ فَمَن تَطَوَّعَ خَيْرًا فَهُوَ خَيْرٌ لَهُ ۚ وَءَن تَصُومُوا خَيْرٌ لَّكُمْ ۖ إِن
كُنْتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ

شَهْرُ رَمَضَانَ الَّذِي أُنْزِلَ فِيهِ الْقُرْءَانُ هُدًى لِّلنَّاسِ وَبَيِّنَاتٍ مِّنَ الْهُدَى وَالْفُرْقَانِ ۚ فَمَن
شَهِدَ مِنْكُمُ الشَّهْرَ فَلْيَصُمْهُ ۚ وَمَن كَانَ مَرِيضًا أَوْ عَلَى سَفَرٍ فَعِدَّةٌ مِّنْ أَيَّامٍ أُخَرَ ۗ يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ
بِكُمُ الْيُسْرَ وَلَا يُرِيدُ بِكُمُ الْعُسْرَ وَلِتُكْمِلُوا الْعِدَّةَ وَلِتُكَبِّرُوا اللَّهَ عَلَى مَا هَدٰكُمْ وَلَعَلَّكُمْ
تَشْكُرُونَ

- *Believers! Fasting has been made obligatory upon you as it was made upon those before you so that you become mindful of God. These are but a few days, but if any one among you is ill or on a journey, let him fast a similar number of days later; and those who have the capacity [to feed a needy] should feed a needy in place of it. Then he who does a virtuous deed of his own accord, it is better for him and if you fast, then this is even better for you if you but knew. It is the month of Ramadan in which the Qur'an was revealed, as a book of guidance for mankind and in the form of manifest arguments which are a means of total guidance and a means of distinguishing right from wrong. Therefore, whoever among you is present in this month, he should fast. And he who is ill or on a journey should fast a similar number of days later on. [This concession is because] God desires ease for you and not discomfort. And [the permission given to travellers and the sick to feed the needy has been withdrawn because] you can complete the fasts [and thus not be deprived of the blessings of fasting] and [for this purpose the month of Ramadan has been fixed so that in the form of the Qur'an] the guidance God has bestowed upon you, you glorify God and express your gratitude to Him. (2:183-185)*

After the prayer and the *zakah*, the fast is the next important worship ritual of Islam. In the Arabic language, the word used for it is (*sawm*), which literally means “to abstain from something” and “to give up something”.

A person expresses himself through deeds and practices; hence when his emotions of worship for the Almighty relate to his deeds and practices then these emotions, besides manifesting in worshipping Him, also manifest in obeying His commands. Fasts are a symbolic expression of this obedience. While fasting, a person, on the command of His lord, gives up things which are originally allowed to him to win the pleasure of his lord; he thus becomes an embodiment of obedience and through his practice acknowledges the fact that there is nothing greater than the command of God. So if the Almighty forbids him things perfectly allowed by innate guidance, then it is only befitting for a person who is the servant of his Creator to obey Him without any hesitation whatsoever.

Objective of the Fast

The objective of the fast as outlined in the above quoted verses of Surah Baqarah is to create the mindfulness of God in a person. The Qur'anic words used are (that you may attain *taqwa*).

Firstly, the fast revives with full force the concept in the mind of a person that he is God's servant. As soon as certain natural desires of the body are given up, the feelings of servitude spring forth and continue to enhance. These feelings totally overwhelm a person at the time of breaking the fast. Right from *fajr* to this time, a person does not consume a single bite of food or a single drop of water merely because his Lord has directed him to refrain from them. When the ritual of the fast is observed every year with vigilance, a profound reality is infused in a person and in fact becomes ingrained in his instincts: he is a servant of his Lord and it is only befitting for him that in other affairs of life also he submit to Him and fully accept His authority by making his concepts and deeds totally subservient to the Almighty.

Secondly, the fast is a means of making a person appreciate the fact from the bottom of his heart that one day he will be held accountable before the Almighty. Although all Muslims believe in this accountability, yet while fasting when the onslaught of thirst, hunger and carnal desire make life difficult for a person it is only this awareness of being accountable before the Almighty that stops a person from fulfilling these needs.

Thirdly, patience is necessary for *taqwa* and it is the fast that produces patience in a person. In fact, to be trained in the trait of patience, perhaps there is no easy and effective a way than the fast. In a nutshell, the trial that we have been put through is that on the one hand we are pulled by our strong physical and carnal desires and on the other hand we are required by the Almighty to live a life within the limits set by Him. This trial requires that we exercise patience at every step of our life. If the traits of honesty, veracity, justice, forbearance, forgiveness, keeping promises, perseverance on the truth, avoiding evil and lust are not present in a person, *taqwa* has no basis and without patience these traits cannot be adopted in a person.

This objective is necessarily achieved through the fast. However, for this, it is essential that those who fast must refrain from certain wrongdoings which strip the fast off its blessings. Although these wrongdoings are numerous, all those who fast must at least be aware of some of them.

- ▶ People tend to make the Ramadan a month of savoring their taste buds.
- ▶ Since hunger and thirst make a person short tempered, some people instead of making the fast a means to control their temper make it an excuse to vent it on others.

The Prophet (sws) is reported to have said: “The fast is a shield; whoever among you fasts should not indulge in vulgar talk nor be overcome by his emotions; then if anyone abuses him or initiates a fight he should respond by saying: ‘I am fasting, my brother, I am fasting.’” (Al Bukhari)

- ▶ People try to find replacements for the food and drinks and other things that they have given up – replacements which they think do not harm the fast in any way thinking that they make it easy for them to spend the time of the fast. They will play cards, read novels and plays, listen to songs, watch movies and gossip with their friends and if they are not able to do these, they would end up backbiting.
- ▶ Sometimes a person does not fast for God; he fasts merely to protect himself from the criticism and condemnation of his family members and friends and sometimes he undertakes the hardship of fasting to pretend religiosity. This too damages the real objective of the fast.